

The Gold Rush

120 kg gold

of the purest category will be required to cover the temple in just the first phase

Rs 12.71 crore

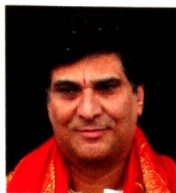
worth of gold and 5,000 tonnes of copper will be used to cover 5,892 sq. ft. of the temple walls in the initial phase

Rs 1,363 crore

was the Tirumala-Tirupathi Devasthanam's budget for 2009-10, which is more than that of many civic authorities

Rs 520 crore

was offered by devotees to the temple in the past year. Rs 70 crore will be generated by selling hair to wig-makers.



We've got 42 kg of gold and Rs 2 crore so far. We have made a beginning. As donations pour in, we will continue the gold-plating project.

K.V. RAMANACHARY, executive officer, TTD

that they are visible on the gold covering. Wafer thin gold foils are then pasted on the copper sheets. All this happens at a high-security workshop under constant CCTV surveillance and metal detectors at doors in the northern wing of the Sri Venkateswara Museum at Tirumala.

Epigraphists and some Hindu religious leaders have raised apprehensions about the invaluable historic and religious inscriptions, dating to the 12th century, on the walls of the temple being lost under all the gold. But the TTD has taken every care to preserve them. "There will be a small gap between the wall and the metal covering to prevent any defacing of the inscription or devaluing in any way its antiquity. For this, we have archived the inscriptions using three different reproduction and conservation techniques," explains TTD

with gold began in AD 1267 when Sundara Pandyan of the Pandyan line of kings had the kalasham of the temple plated with gold.

The TTD is hopeful of raising both gold and cash as the work progresses on completing the outer wall. After Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy launched the scheme on October 1 last year, cash and gold offerings in all shapes and sizes have been flooding in. "We have got 42 kg of gold and Rs 2 crore so far," says Ramanachary. For the initial phase, the TTD will require more than 120 kg of pure gold and 5,000 tonnes of copper. It is estimated that covering 5,892 square feet of the temple walls will cost Rs 12.71 crore. For all this the TTD will rely on donations instead of dipping into its legendary reserves of gold and cash. The money that accrues from acts of faith is already committed to numerous ongoing schemes and projects administered by the TTD. "We have made a beginning and as the donations keep pouring in, we are confident of taking up the gold plating project in phases," avers an optimistic Ramanachary.

The TTD's budget is more than that of many urban civic authorities in the country. Its revenue is expected to be Rs 1,363 crore in 2009-10, Rs 232.65 crore more than what it earned in 2008-09. Interest on investments will be Rs 487 crore, Rs 230 crore more than what the TTD got in 2008-09. Devotees' offerings, the biggest chunk, will touch Rs 521 crore. The offering of human hair by devotees—when sold to wig makers—fetches Rs 70 crore annually. Perhaps the only direct expense of the temple for devotees is on *prasadam*s, mainly laddus, which cost Tirumala Rs 60 crore each year, while it gets Rs 40 crore in return for them. In the eyes of the faithful, all that is gold glitters the brightest. ■



ARTISANS MAKE COPPER SHEETS WHICH WILL BE COVERED WITH THIN GOLD FOILS TO BE PLACED ON THE TEMPLE WALLS

About 60 craftsmen are engaged in pure gold leaf *malam* work on copper sheets. This is an arduous task—malleable copper sheets are first heated to extreme temperatures in a special kiln and then beaten into required shapes. Special care is taken to ensure that the existing motifs of elephants and horses on the walls are not damaged when the sheets are put up and

Executive Officer K.V. Ramanachary. While a team of the Archaeological Survey of India has created its own scientific record of the inscriptions for posterity, complete with conservation measures, other teams from the TTD have prepared a digital record as well as a photographic repository.

The temple is not new to glitter. The exercise of plating the temple